NETHERBLOOM

Book of Remembrance



The King on the Barge

The old grave-texts told the dead: do not drink from Lethe; find the spring of Memory. This Book is that spring.

THE SOUL OF THIS BOOK

The King on the Barge

A crown carried long after the kingdom fell.

He was a boy when he drew a sword that no one else could move, and a king before he was a man. For years he won every battle he rode to. He built a hall with a round table so that no knight would sit higher than another, and he believed, because he was young, that a fair table would make a fair world.

The sword he carried into those battles was not his. A hand clothed in white had risen from a lake and lent it to him, and he had promised it would go back to the water when his work was done. He meant to keep that promise. There was always one more war first.

His dearest friend was the best of his knights, and his friend loved the queen, and the queen loved his friend, more honestly than either of them loved him. He knew it long before he let himself know it. When at last it came out, the fellowship of the table broke into halves, then quarters, then into men killing each other on a field of his own making. He held the line long after the line was lost. At the end of that day only a handful were standing, and he was not among them.

They laid him on a black barge with three veiled women at the prow and pushed him out into the mist. On that barge he forgave them both, his friend and his queen, too late to tell either of them. The sword was never returned to the lake. He still wears the crown, and it grows heavier every year. The old ferryman would not take him: a king, he says, pays in debts, and this one has not paid.



What the Ferrymen know

His companions still answer when he calls: while he crosses, a Mantle costs only 2 Light. But his fellowship was always fragile. A Fracture strips the Mantle from the Ferryman who caused it, as his round table was once stripped bare, one empty chair at a time.

Twist: Mantles cost 2 Light. A Fracture strips the Mantle of the player who caused it.

Key Memory: *the hand that rose from the lake to give me a sword*



Keeping the Book

The Book has one page per Reach. Each page has four slots, **Place**, **Person**, **Deed** and **Feeling**, which fill a sentence about the soul's life.

You may **inscribe** a card when it Resonates, if its memory's slot is still empty on the current page. A **Key Memory** card may be inscribed whenever it is played face up. An inscribed card leaves the deck for good: you trade a useful card for a memory the soul will keep.

Chapter Blessing. When a page holds 3 memories (2 for the Garland Girl), the river grants the first of these that applies: mend a Fracture, drain Black Water, or return a forgotten card.

At the end, the Book is read aloud. Slots never filled read "...but this, the river has taken".

Tuck an inscribed card into the well for its slot: slide its four corners under the slits. Slide it out again to reuse the card next game.

I · Who I Was

I was born near...



I loved...



I once...



and ever since I have carried...



☐ Chapter Blessing

Keepsakes ☐ ☐ ☐

II · What I Did

At...



PLACE

...but this, the river has taken

before...



PERSON

...but this, the river has taken

I...



DEED

...but this, the river has taken

The price was...



FEELING

...but this, the river has taken

☐ Chapter Blessing

Keepsakes ☐☐☐

III · What I Carry

I go now, leaving...



PLACE

...but this, the river has taken

forgiving...



PERSON

...but this, the river has taken

unable to undo the day I...



DEED

...but this, the river has taken

holding only...



FEELING

...but this, the river has taken

☐ Chapter Blessing

Keepsakes ☐☐☐

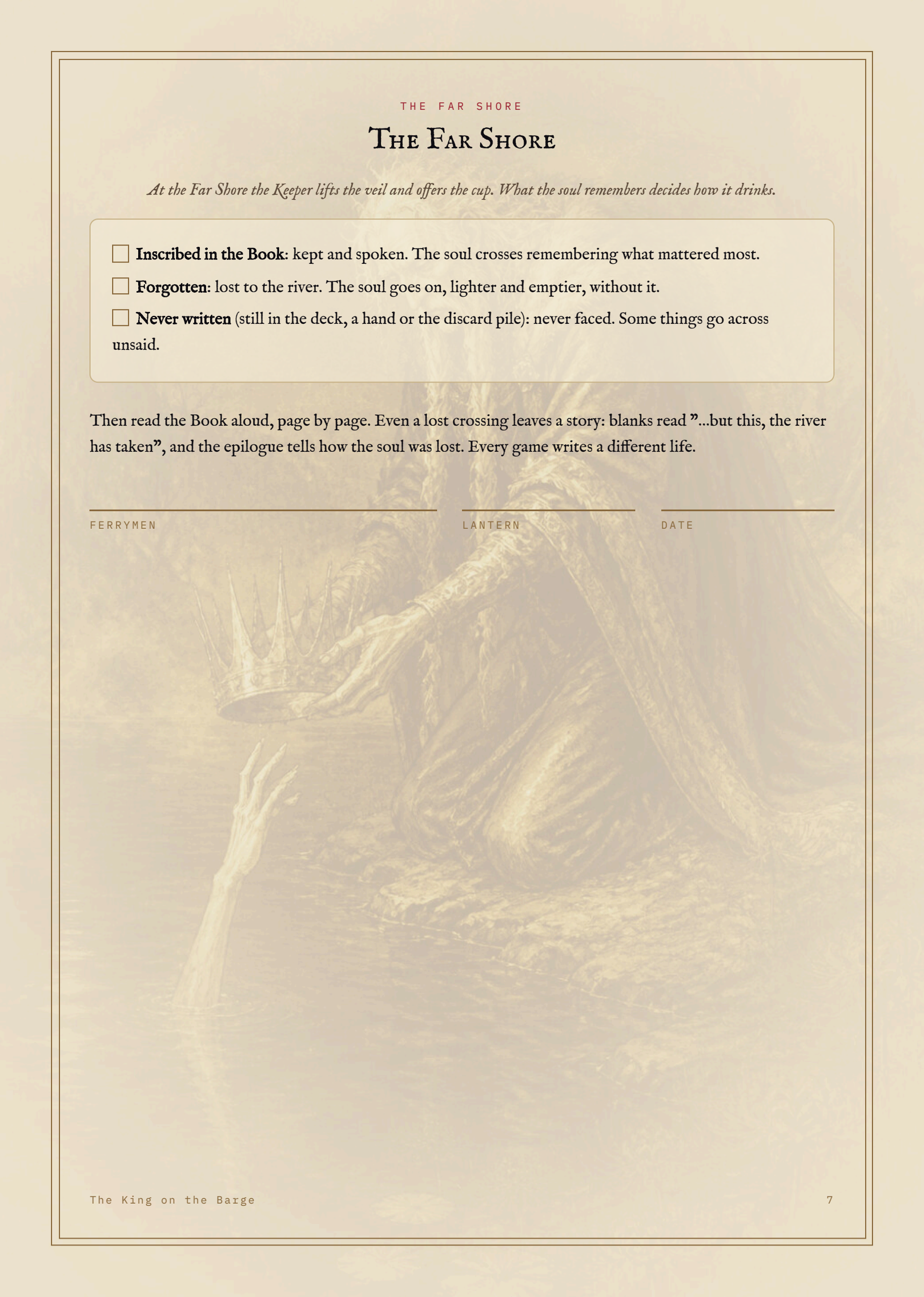
The Far Shore

At the Far Shore the Keeper lifts the veil and offers the cup. What the soul remembers decides how it drinks.

- ☐ **Inscribed in the Book**: kept and spoken. The soul crosses remembering what mattered most.
- ☐ **Forgotten**: lost to the river. The soul goes on, lighter and emptier, without it.
- ☐ **Never written** (still in the deck, a hand or the discard pile): never faced. Some things go across unsaid.

Then read the Book aloud, page by page. Even a lost crossing leaves a story: blanks read "...but this, the river has taken", and the epilogue tells how the soul was lost. Every game writes a different life.

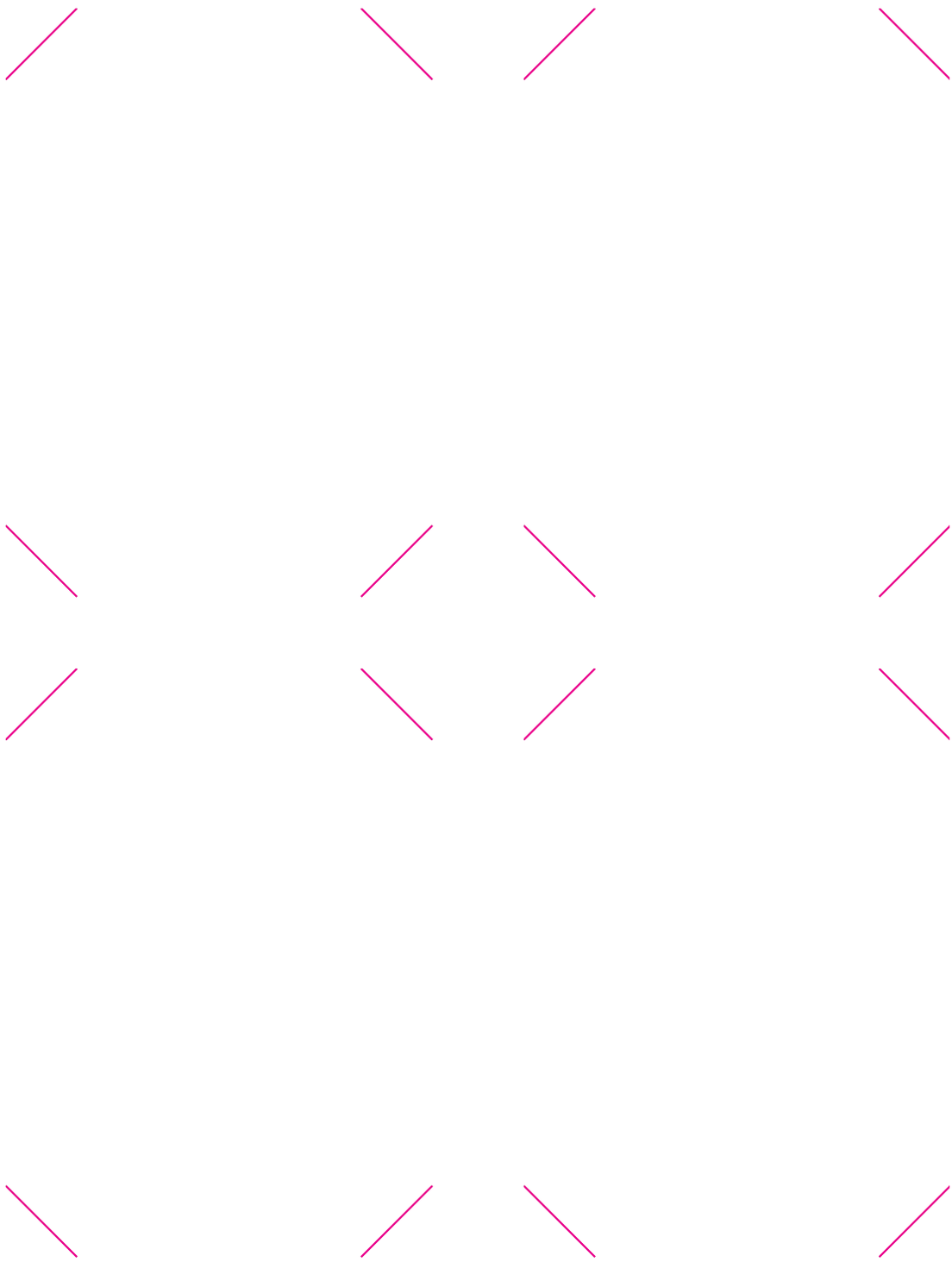
FERRYMEN _____ LANTERN _____ DATE _____





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RALPH LAUXIE



DIE LINE · pages 4–6 · photo-corner slits (magenta), 11 mm diagonals at each corner of the four 66 × 91 mm wells